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Affairs of the Heart and State

IN ANCIENT NARRATIONS OF ASHOKA'S LIFE, ROMANTIC passion appears for the first time when the Pataliputra prince is sent to Malwa in Central India. Tellings of this intersect with him falling in love with a young woman who is known in the ancient Sri Lankan textual tradition as a Buddhist.

Her name was Devi and the romance began in the city of Vidisha, where her father was a prominent merchant. Soon enough, Ashoka married Devi and moved on to Ujjayini. Ordinarily, romantic love is a popular theme in ancient India's epics as well as in numerous plays that revolve around the romances of princes and kings in royal courts and cities, sometimes the same story being told and retold across many centuries.[1] The famous love story of King Dushyanta and Shakuntala in the *Mahabharata* is one of these and became the theme of Kalidasa's (*c*. fourth–fifth centuries CE) play *Abhijanashakuntala*, which brings love to life in the way that the best drama does. Unluckily, this variety of interest cannot be discerned in the Buddhist literary sources. Their purposes being religious rather than literary, description of the dynamics of a future Buddhist king's romantic relationship is fairly peripheral to the templates of their narratives. Ashoka's whirlwind courtship of Devi are fleeting and passionless despite, it seems, this relationship being life-changing.